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IDIOMS AND PHRASES

A few questions are asked on idioms and phrases in the CDS exam. In the CDS exam, questions on idioms and phrases are asked in a sentence format. The candidate is given a sentence in which an idiom or phrase would be underlined. The candidate has to select the meaning of the idiom /phrase by choosing the correct option from the given choices.



Idioms and Phrases form an essential part of any language. They add power, meaning and crispness to our everyday expressions, conversations and writings. There is a huge number of idioms, phrases and proverbs in English and we should not hesitate to use them to enhance the beauty of the language. Idioms and phrases do have an ornamental value but more than that, they are tools which can be used to get the desired impact.

Idioms are usually comprised of very few words but encompassed in them is a deep meaning. So, when one is at a dearth for words, Idioms can easily come to the rescue. We can put forth our thoughts more effectively and in an impressive manner using them.

The only disadvantage in using them is that in our eagerness and enthusiasm to impress others, we normally do not spend any time in understanding the meaning of the idiom. It is very crucial to do this because using an idiom inappropriately can entirely change the meaning of the sentence or twist the truth.

Idioms add value and power to our expressions, only if we use them accurately and efficiently.

Some Important Idioms and Phrases

1. **A blessing in disguise** Something good that isn't recognised at first.
2. **A chip on your shoulder** To seem angry all the time because you think you have been treated unfairly or feel you are not as good as other people.
3. **A dime a dozen** Anything that is common and easy to get.
4. **A doubting Thomas** A skeptic who needs physical or personal evidence in order to believe something.
5. **A drop in the bucket** A very small part of something big or whole.
6. **A fool and his money are easily parted** It's easy for a foolish person to lose his/her money.
7. **A house divided against itself cannot stand** If the members of a group fight each other, the group will disintegrate.
8. **A leopard can't change his spots** A person's character especially if it is bad, will not change, even if they pretend it has.
9. **A penny saved is a penny earned** By not spending money, you are saving money (little by little).
10. **A picture paints a thousand words** A visual presentation is far more descriptive than words.
11. **A piece of cake** A task that can be accomplished very easily.
12. **A slap on the wrist** A very mild punishment.
13. **A taste of your own medicine** When you are mistreated the same way you mistreat others.
14. **A toss-up** A situation where two or more possibilities are equally likely.
15. **Actions speak louder than words** It's better to actually do something than just talk about it.
16. **Add fuel to the fire** Something done to make a bad situation even worse than it is.
17. **Against the clock** against time; in a great hurry to get something done before a particular time.
18. **All bark and no bite** When someone is threatening and/or is aggressive but not willing to engage in a fight.
19. **All Greek to me** Something that is meaningless and incomprehensible to someone.
20. **All in the same boat** When everyone is facing the same challenges.
21. **An arm and a leg** Very expensive, costing a large amount of money.
22. **Have an axe to grind** To have a strong personal opinion about something that you want people to accept and that is the reason you do something.
23. **Apple of my eye** Someone who is cherished above all others.
24. **Be as high as a kite** To feel very happy and excited.
25. **At the drop of a hat** Willing to do something immediately.
26. **Back to square one** Having to start all over again.
27. **Back to the drawing board** Back to the beginning or planning phase after an approach has proved unsuccessful.
28. **Barking up the wrong tree** To be wrong about the reason for something or the way to achieve something.
29. **Beat a dead horse** To waste effort on something when there is no chance of succeeding.
30. **Beating around the bush** Avoiding the main topic, not speaking directly about the issue.
31. **Bend over backwards** To go out of one's way to do something for someone.
32. **Between a rock and a hard place** Stuck between two very bad options.
33. **Bite off more than you can chew** To decide or agree to do more than one can finally accomplish.
34. **Bite your tongue** To stop yourself from saying something that you would really like to say.
35. **Blood is thicker than water** Said to emphasize that you believe that family connections are always more important than other types of relationship.
36. **Once in a blue moon** To do something rarely.
37. **Break a leg** A superstitious way to say 'good luck' without saying 'good luck', but rather the opposite.
38. **Buy a lemon** To purchase a vehicle that constantly gives problems or stops running after you drive it away.
39. **Can't cut the mustard** Unable to deal with problems or difficulties.
40. **Cast iron stomach** Someone who has no problems, complications or ill effects with eating anything or drinking anything.
41. **Charley horse** A cramp in your arm or leg.
42. **Chew someone out** Verbally scold someone.
43. **Chow down** To eat something usually quickly, saying something rude or unpleasant.
44. **Close but no cigar** To be very near and almost accomplish a goal, but fall short.
45. **Cock and bull story** An unbelievable tale.
46. **Come hell or high water** To decide to do something no matter what happens.

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47. **Crack someone up** To make someone laugh.
48. **Cross your fingers** To hope that something happens the way you want it to.
49. **Cry over spilt milk** To regret in vain about what cannot be undone or rectified.
50. **Cry wolf** Intentionally raise a false alarm.
51. **Cup of joe** A cup of coffee.
52. **Curiosity kills the cat** Being inquisitive can lead you into a dangerous situation.
53. **Cut to the chase** Leave out all the unnecessary details and get to the main point.
54. **Dark horse** Someone who unexpectedly wins a competition.
55. **A dead ringer for someone/ something** Someone or something that looks exactly like someone or something else.
56. **Devil's advocate** Someone who argues against a cause or position either for the sake of argument or to help determine its validity.
57. **Dog days of summer** The hottest days of the summer season.
58. **Don't count your chickens before they hatch** Don't make plans based on future events that might not happen.
59. **Don't look a gift horse in the mouth** When someone gives you a gift, accept it graciously.
60. **Don't put all your eggs in one basket** To not put all your resources in one area.
61. **Down to the wire** Until the last possible moment.
62. **Drastic times call for drastic measures** When you are extremely desperate you need to take extremely desperate actions.
63. **Drive someone up the wall** To irritate and/or annoy someone very much.
64. **Dropping like flies** A large number of people either falling ill or dying.
65. **Dry run** Rehearsal; a dummy run or show.
66. **Elvis has left the building** The show has come to an end; it's all over.
67. **Ethnic cleansing** Killing of a certain ethnic or religious group on a massive scale.
68. **Every cloud has a silver lining** There is something good even in an unpleasant situation.
69. **Everything but the kitchen sink** Almost everything imaginable.
70. **Feeding frenzy** A situation in which people try to get as much as possible of something, for example information about an event, especially in an unpleasant way.
71. **Field day** A time of great pleasure, activity or opportunity.
72. **Finding your feet** To become familiar with and confident in a new situation.
73. **Fixed in your ways** Not willing or wanting to change from your normal way of doing something.
74. **Flash in the pan** Something that happened only once or for a short time and was not repeated.
75. **Flesh and blood** The quality of being alive.
76. **Foam at the mouth** To be extremely angry.
77. **From rags to riches** To go from being very poor to being very wealthy.
78. **Get down to brass tacks** To start talking about the most important or basic facts of a situation.
79. **Get over it** To move beyond something that is bothering you.
80. **Get up on the wrong side of the bed** To begin the day feeling unhappy and uncomfortable.
81. **Get your walking papers** To get fired from a job.
82. **Give him the slip** To get away from or escape someone.
83. **Go down like a lead balloon** To be received badly by an audience.
84. **Go for broke** To gamble everything you have.
85. **Go out on a limb** Put yourself in a tough position in order to support someone/something.
86. **Go the extra mile** Going above and beyond whatever is required for the task at hand.
87. **Good Samaritan** Someone who helps others when they are in need, with no discussion for compensation and no thought of a reward.
88. **Great minds think alike** Intelligent people think like each other.
89. **Green room** The waiting room, especially for those who are about to go on a TV or radio show.
90. **Gut feeling** Sense something about a person or situation, without knowing why, but you're sure what you sense is right.
91. **Haste makes waste** Quickly doing things results in a poor ending.
92. **Have clean hands** Be guiltless.
93. **He lost his head** To be angry and overcome by emotions.
94. **Head over heels** To be very excited or joyful, especially when in love.
95. **To be going to hell in a hand basket** To be rapidly deteriorating – on course for disaster.
96. **Hit the books** To study especially for a test or an exam.
97. **Hit the hay** Go to bed or go to sleep.

- 98. Hit the nail on the head** Do something exactly right or say something exactly right.
- 99. Hit the sack** Go to bed or go to sleep.
- 100. Hold your horses** To be patient.
- 101. Icing on the cake** When you already have it good and get something on top of what you already have.
- 102. Idle hands are the devil's tools** You are more likely to get in trouble if you have nothing to do.
- 103. If it's not one thing, it's another** Used when bad things keep happening to you.
- 104. In like Flynn** To quickly or easily achieve goal or gain access to something.
- 105. In the bag** To have something secured.
- 106. In the buff** Nude.
- 107. In the heat of the moment** Overwhelmed by what is happening in the moment.
- 108. In your face** Characterised by or expressive of bold and often defiant aggressiveness.
- 109. It takes two to tango** If two people are involved in a bad situation, both must be responsible.
- 110. It's a small world** You frequently see the same people in different places.
- 111. Its anyone's call** A competition where the outcome is difficult to judge or predict.
- 112. Keep an eye on someone** To keep someone or something under careful observation.
- 113. Keep body and soul together** To earn a sufficient amount of money in order to keep yourself alive.
- 114. Keep your chin up** To remain joyful in a tough situation.
- 115. Kick the bucket** Die.
- 116. Knee jerk reaction** A quick reaction that doesn't allow you time to consider something carefully.
- 117. Know the ropes** Be informed about the details of a situation or task.
- 118. Last but not the least** An introduction phrase to let the audience know that the last person or thing mentioned is no less important than those introduced before him/her.
- 119. Lend me your ear** To politely ask for someone's full attention.
- 120. Let bygones be bygones** To forget about unpleasant things that have happened in the past.
- 121. Let sleeping dogs lie** Said to warn someone that they should not talk about a bad situation that most people have forgotten about.
- 122. Let the cat out of the bag** To share a secret that wasn't suppose to be shared.
- 123. Level playing field** A fair competition where no side has an advantage.
- 124. Like a chicken with its head cut off** To act in a frenzied manner.
- 125. Liquor someone up** To get someone drunk.
- 126. Live high on the hog** To live in great comfort with a lot of money.
- 127. Long in the tooth** To be very old.
- 128. Loose cannon** Someone who behaves in an uncontrolled or unexpected way and is likely to cause problems for other people.
- 129. Make no bones about** Having no hesitation in stating or dealing with something, however unpleasant or awkward it is.
- 130. Method to my madness** Strange or crazy actions that appear meaningless but in the end are done for a good reason.
- 131. Mumbo jumbo** Confusing or meaningless words or activity.
- 132. Mum's the word** Used to say that some information is being kept secret or should be kept secret.
- 133. Nest egg** Savings set aside for future use.
- 134. Never bite the hand that feeds you** To not hurt anyone that helps you.
- 135. New kid on the block** Someone new to the group.
- 136. New York minute** A minute that seems to go by quickly, especially in a fast paced environment.
- 137. No room to swing a cat** An unusually small or confined space.
- 138. Not playing with a full deck** Not mentally sound; crazy or mentally deranged.
- 139. Get off on the wrong foot** Getting a bad start on a relationship or task.
- 140. Off the hook** To escape from a difficult situation.
- 141. Off the record** Not intended to be known publicly or recorded officially.
- 142. On pins and needles** Anxious or nervous, especially in anticipation of something.
- 143. On the fence** Undecided about something.
- 144. Be on the same page** To understand or agree with what is being done or suggested.
- 145. Out of the blue** Something that suddenly and unexpectedly occurs.
- 146. Over my dead body** When you absolutely will not allow something to happen.
- 147. Over the top** Too extreme and not suitable, or demanding too much attention or effort, especially in an uncontrolled way.
- 148. Pass the buck** To pass the blame; to give the responsibility to someone else.

- 149. Pedal to the metal** To make something go forward or increase as fast as possible.
- 150. Pick up your ears** To listen very carefully.
- 151. A pig in a poke** Something that you buy without knowing if it is good or not.
- 152. Pig out** To eat a lot and eat it quickly.
- 153. Pipe down** To shut-up or be quiet.
- 154. Pull the plug** To stop something, to bring something to an end.
- 155. Queer the pitch** Destroy or ruin a plan.
- 156. Raining cats and dogs** To be raining in great amounts.
- 157. Rome was not built in a day** If you want something to be completed properly then its going to take time.
- 158. Rule of thumb** A practical and approximate way of doing something.
- 159. Run out of steam** To be completely out of energy.
- 160. Saved by the bell** When a difficult situation ends suddenly before you have to do or say something that you do not want to.
- 161. Sick as a dog** To be very ill.
- 162. Smell a rat** To recognise that something is not as it seems to be or that something dishonest is happening.
- 163. Smell something fishy** Detecting that something isn't right or someone is being dishonest.
- 164. Son of a gun** A worthless person.
- 165. Southpaw** Someone who is left-handed.
- 166. Spitting image** To look extremely similar to someone.
- 167. Start from scratch** To do it all over again from the beginning.
- 168. The ball is in your court** It is upto you to make the next move.
- 169. The best of both worlds** A situation in which you can enjoy the advantages of two very different things at the same time.
- 170. The bigger they are the harder they fall** The more powerful and successful people are, the more they suffer when they experience defeat and disaster.
- 171. The last straw** The final difficulty in a series; the last little burden or problem that causes everything to collapse.
- 172. The whole nine yards** Everything; the entire amount.
- 173. Third time's a charm** After no success the first two times, the third try is a lucky one.
- 174. Tie the knot** To get married.
- 175. Until the cows come home** For a very long time.
- 176. To make a long story short** As a way to avoid a long explanation.
- 177. To steal someone's thunder** To take the credit for something someone else did.
- 178. Tongue in cheek** If you say something tongue in cheek, you intend it to be understood as a joke, although you might appear to be serious.
- 179. Turn a blind eye** Refuse to acknowledge something you know is real or legitimate.
- 180. Twenty three skidoo** To leave quickly.
- 181. Under the weather** Feeling ill or sick.
- 182. Up a blind alley** At a dead end; on a route that leads nowhere.
- 183. Van Gogh's ear for music** When referring to a singer it implies that he/she is not good and tend to go off key a lot.
- 184. Variety is the spice of life** New and exciting experiences make life more interesting.
- 185. Wag the dog** To purposely direct the attention from something of greater importance to something of lesser importance.
- 186. Water under the bridge** Anything from the past that isn't significant or important anymore.
- 187. Wear your heart on your sleeve** To openly and freely express your emotions.
- 188. When it rains, it pours** Many difficult things happening at the same time.
- 189. When pigs fly** Something that will never ever happen.
- 190. Wild and woolly** Uncultured and without laws.
- 191. You are what you eat** In order to stay healthy you must eat healthy foods.
- 192. You can't judge a book by its cover** You cannot judge the quality or character of someone or something just by looking at them.
- 193. You can't take it with you** When you die you cannot take things such as money or property with you.
- 194. Your guess is as good as mine** Something you say when you do not know the answer to a question.